

Reality on the Shores of America



FOR LONG, ANURAG Mathur's bestselling novel *The Inscrutable Americans* has been the benchmark in the confused-desi-in-America genre in Indian writing. It remained on the Indian best-seller list for a record seven years with no signs of leaving the Top 10 club. S Mitra Kalita's *Suburban Sahibs*, although steeped in fact and technically not in the same genre as Mathur's fast-paced poke at Indians trying to find the 'real' America, tries hard to beat the notion of a confused diaspora created by Mathur and later propagated by various movie including 'American Born Confused Desi'. It is a sincere effort, worthy of praise, but you get the same feeling you get when you miss the dessert after a hearty meal—something, somewhere seems to be missing even if you feel full.

Kalita's credentials, though, are impeccable—she is a reporter with The Washington Post and the head of the prestigious New York-based South Asian Journalists Association—and her writing skills are

beyond reproach. Her ability to get detail out of the most trivial matter betrays her journalistic instincts.

She tracks the lives of three families wanting to make it big in the US, amongst which are people naturally wanting to make it big with their H1B visas—their passports to technological heaven. Without being too sentimental about it, Kalita writes about the rise and fall of the dotcom generation, and how the technology layoffs in the US hurt the Indian economy in their wake.

Most importantly, Kalita records reality—something most tend to ignore when they reach America's shores and view the country with rose-tinted glasses. Reality dawns, albeit a bit late.

It is this virtue that makes *Suburban Sahibs* a readable book. It is not an unputdownable book—but it is definitely a competent effort that made US Senator Bill Bradley say: "It is beautiful book to be enjoyed by all."

Aparna Krishnakumar

Suburban Sahibs

Publisher **Penguin Books** Authors **S Mitra Kalita**
Phone **011-2649 0361/4401** Fax **011-2649 4403** E-mail
customer.service@in.pengroup.com
Web site **www.penguinbooksindia.com** Price **Rs 250**

No Better than a Rugby Game

FROM THE HARRY Potter books by J K Rowling, one would assume that Quidditch is a racy, lively game. But Electronic Arts hugely disappoints with *Harry Potter: Quidditch World Cup*, which is nothing but rugby played in the air.

QWC has great graphics, and the tutorials are good, too, compared to the previous Potter games. One major hurdle is that you must play a tutorial before starting a match against another house team.

Despite the beautiful design of the arenas or 'pitches', the gameplay gets sluggish and boring. You are forced to play more than half the matches at your own national stadium. The character porting is meticulous. Special moves are another cool aspect of the game. While holding the Quaffle, you get to perform special moves that help you score goals whopping fast.

EA screwed up even the innovative special moves. These moves cannot be



blocked, and this can get very frustrating. Even the control system disappoints. EA seems to have assumed that the gamepad is the standard PC peripheral. The layout of the keyboard commands is cumbersome.

The game is highly recommended for all Potter maniacs. However, chances are that the casual gamer will find he's better off playing FIFA 2004.

Harry Potter: Quidditch World Cup

Publisher **Electronic Arts**
Developer **Electronic Arts**
Web site **harrypotter.ea.com**

5

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List courtesy: Crossword, Mumbai

Prince Of Persia: The Sands of Time (PS2)

Publisher **Ubisoft**
Developer **Ubisoft Montreal**
Web site **www.prince-of-persia.com**



Swinging Times

JORDAN MECHNER'S *PRINCE of Persia*, developed by Broderbund Software back in the hoary days of yore, was a masterpiece. *Prince of Persia: The Sands of Time* (SOT) is the 3D sequel to that classic title, and it remains faithful to its predecessor in remarkably creative ways.

The game begins in medieval times, shortly after the Prince and his father the king have defeated a Maharajah and looted his palace.

You have to travel through the entirety

of the palace, use wits, acrobatics, the sword, avoid traps, kill enemies, fall and rewind, and... fall in love? Well, you do meet a beautiful princess and an intriguing sub-plot unfolds.

A major part of the gameplay lies with the Dagger of Time. If you fall off a cliff, miss a jump, fall down a ladder, or get lured into a trap, you activate the Dagger of Time, which turns back time before your eyes. The environments and dialogues are all top-notch.

This is a tough game to beat. If you liked *Prince*, you'll love *SOT*.